Getting Ready Is Not the Same as Deciding

A short guide to planning ahead for Mom's care.

Putting Mom's care notes in one folder is preparation. Choosing where she'll live is a decision. In many families the two get talked about as if they were one thing, which is how one relative ends up wanting to tour places while another would rather not talk about it at all.

This guide explains the difference and what a family with time can do with it. It doesn't decide anything, and it doesn't assess Mom.

Prepare without forcing action

Preparation is anything that helps whatever happens: asking Mom what she wants, gathering what the family already knows, agreeing who keeps the notes. A decision commits Mom to something: where she lives, which place, and when. A future care plan doesn't need a guessed move-in date. It needs useful preparation, clear family roles, and a way to recognize when new decisions are required.

You don't have to know when more care will be needed, or whether it will. The federal Administration for Community Living says the duration and level of long-term care vary from person to person and often change over time. [1]

AARP's planning guide for families adds the other half: every family caregiving plan must center on the wishes of the person receiving the care, and a plan should never be made without her participation, knowledge and consent. Getting ready is something you do with Mom. [2]

- A test for anything on the family's list: would it still be useful whatever happens? If so, it's preparation.
- Word the decisions you're leaving as things the family has chosen to wait on. That's different from ruling them out.

Turn what's on people's minds into small next steps

A concern has no next step attached. “What if she gets lonely out there?” is a concern. “Ask Mom who she sees in an ordinary week” is a task: small, specific, and something one person can do.

The Family Caregiver Alliance's advice for family meetings is to hold off on solving problems until the issues have been explored, and to record them in a list as they're shared. A written list is where concerns start turning into tasks. [3]

Some items are neither a task nor a family decision. They're questions for a professional. AARP's guide notes that a nurse or social worker can help a family determine what is needed. Keep those items on the page, with a note of who will ask. [2]

- A task is something to do. A decision is something to choose. Mark which is which.
- Anything about Mom's health goes on the list for her doctor.

Put the work in order, and fit it to the people

Some things wait on others. A conversation about what Mom would want comes before anything that depends on her answer. Noting what each item is waiting on shows which ones can start now.

Some things aren't actions at all. They're things to keep an eye on. Give them a list of their own, so nobody mistakes them for something to act on.

And the work has to fit the people doing it. The Family Caregiver Alliance notes that caregiving may start when the sibling who lives nearby helps out with small things, and that the others may assume that person has everything covered. AARP's guide adds that team members need not all live nearby or have huge blocks of time to be of value. [4] [2]

MedlinePlus, from the National Library of Medicine, suggests making a list of ways others can help and letting helpers choose what they'd like to do. The Family Caregiver Alliance suggests asking directly, being specific, and asking for what's realistic. [5] [4]

- Break the preparation into pieces small enough for an afternoon, and note which ones could be done from out of town.
- A name goes beside a piece only when that person has said yes.

Make it a shared page with a reason to open it again

A plan one person carries in their head isn't shared. The Family Caregiver Alliance suggests a written summary of what each person has agreed to, and making sure each person understands what they've agreed to do. [3]

A shared page also needs a reason to be opened again. The CDC's advice for a care plan is to update it every year, or more often if the person's health or medicines change. The Family Caregiver Alliance says family meetings aren't a one-time event, and should at least take place when the caregiving situation, or other situations in family members' lives, change. [6] [3]

So the page carries a date for the next look and a short list of everyday changes that would bring the family back sooner. For the pieces that matter most, it also helps to know who has offered to step in if the first person can't.

Which changes should count for Mom, and what any of them would mean, isn't something a guide can say. That belongs to the people who assess her.

What this means for your family

- Once preparation and decisions are sorted apart, the aim is a list of useful things nobody in the family would object to.
- The family's part right now is to get things ready, with Mom, and to leave the decisions that aren't due where they are.
- The preparation belongs to more than one person, in pieces people have chosen.
- The page ends with a date, and a few everyday changes that would bring you back to it.
- Questions about Mom's health go to her doctor. Questions about how the pieces fit together can go to your care consultant.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't say what Mom needs, when anything will be needed or where she should live, and it doesn't build your family's roadmap. The advice credited to an organization comes from the sources below. The difference between getting ready and deciding, and the advice about what to write down, are ours.

Ready for the next step?

You can now tell getting something ready from deciding it. The care interview gives the plan something to stand on: it walks you through Mom's situation as it is today, area by area, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. Administration for Community Living, How Much Care Will You Need?
2. AARP, Prepare to Care: A Planning Guide for Families
3. Family Caregiver Alliance, Holding a Family Meeting
4. Family Caregiver Alliance, Caregiving with Your Siblings
5. MedlinePlus (National Library of Medicine, NIH), Caregiver Health
6. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention, Steps for Creating and Maintaining a Care Plan

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From the Family Care Roadmap · Richard Ladson, Certified Medicaid Planner. Draft for review, generated 2026-10-04.